aided a non-communist country. Bilateral trade increased sevenfold between 1955 and 1957.[2] More importantly from the perspective of relations with China, the Soviets agreed to Indian arms purchases.

By the mid-1950s, then, non-aligned India, after an initial period of hesitation and awkwardness, was developing friendlier ties with both the US and the USSR. The two powers in turn, after their initial scepticism over Nehru's foreign policy, had come to appreciate that India was worth cultivating.

China allies with the USSR

Communist China began its journey in international politics as a brother-state to the USSR. In fact, its partnership with the Soviets went back further, to the pre-communist days of Chiang Kai-shek and the KMT. From the 1920s to 1941, Moscow was often only grudgingly supportive of the CPC. When the KMT entered its death spiral against the CPC on the mainland, Moscow finally changed sides. As a result, in 1949, Mao went to Moscow to see Josef Stalin. Despite being kept humiliatingly waiting for several weeks, he went on to sign the Sino-Soviet Treaty of Friendship, Alliance, and Mutual Assistance in 1950. Under treaty terms, the USSR returned Chinese territories it had acquired from Japan after defeating it in the Second World War. It also provided Beijing with economic assistance, military factories, and nuclear plants. When Chinese troops were flung against the US-led United Nations troops in Korea in 1950, the Soviets, after initial hesitations, helped China with air cover.

By 1956, in the aftermath of Stalin's death, China and the Soviets were heading for a collision. Khrushchev's de-Stalinization programme and his 'peaceful coexistence' policy towards the West alarmed Mao, who denounced Moscow for being 'Marxist revisionist'. Moscow in turn thought that Beijing was geopolitically adventurist. Mao's aggressive stance on Taiwan in the mid-1950s alarmed the Soviets, as did China's insouciance over a possible nuclear war with the US. As the name-calling climaxed,